

Nick Heindl

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Technical Accessibility Champion

Technical and resourceful champion of accessibility with 10+ years of AAA gameplay XP across titles that have been enjoyed by nearly one billion players worldwide.

With a background in gameplay engineering and tech design, Nick latest's position had him combine this technical expertise and love of inclusive design to form, and lead, a new team dedicated to ensuring our MMORPG, with a new IP and technology stack, would be accessible from Day 1.

Nick has an infectious passion for game accessibility, learning new technologies and techniques, collaborating with different roles, and empowering teams to do their best work. "Force Multiplier", "Mentor", and "Advocate" are all terms used by previous leads to describe Nick and his impact.

Leadership and Collaboration

ZeniMax Online Studios (Xbox, Bethesda) | August 2021 – Present

- Founded and led a new Accessibility Team for a large-scale MMORPG project (350+ devs)
- Drove strategy for player-facing and developer-facing accessibility features and infrastructure
- Collaborated closely with internal and external stakeholders to create multi-year roadmaps
- Defined goals and success metrics for various development phases (pre-prod to post-launch)
- Contributed to Xbox-wide talks and initiatives related to Design, Accessibility, and Publishing
- Ran workshops, presentations, and 1-1s to build a culture of empathy and inclusive design
- Ensured we were on track to meet (and exceed) legal and publishing standards and guidelines
- Ran playtests alongside UR and UX in effort to collate feedback into prioritized action items
- Worked with various cross-functional teams to improve accessibility of development tools
- Established standards for text scaling on multiple platforms (Console, PC, Handheld, Mobile)
- Onboarded and trained multiple tech designers; Mentored many designers across departments

PUBG Corporation | October 2020 – July 2021

- Brought on to help kickstart a new engineering team at a young studio
- Assisted Tech Director with setting up a recruiting and interviewing process

Raven Software (Activision Blizzard) | Summer 2015 – October 2020

- Led two small, multidisciplinary teams in Activision-wide innovation competitions
- Collaborated with worldwide teams to set up analytics design & instrumentation for Warzone
- Engineering mentor to interns and folks in many departments (Eng./Design/QA)
- Travelled with the University Relations team to recruit at schools across the US

Personal

- Actively coaching and mentoring students and presenting talks and panels to conferences
- Certified Accessible Player Experience Practitioner (CAPXP): accessible.games/apxp

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Technical Proficiency

ZeniMax Online Studios | New ECS-based engine, AngelScript, C++, C#, Figma, Miro

- Performed technical evaluations and breakdowns of third-party software, (IRIS, Chroma, etc.)
- Worked closely with 3Cs team to balance movement and camera to minimize Sim Sickness
- Partnered with Combat team to revamp Aim Assist systems and give designers live-edit tooling
- Created a demo to showcase our assistive devices utilizing our input binding tech
- Created comparisons, designs, and mockups for features using tools like Figma and Miro
- Technical Product Owner of Narrative Systems from first implementation through prototype
- Led effort to assess, prototype, and scale up various systems by architecting a Murder Mystery

PUBG Corporation | Unreal Engine 4, C++, PowerShell

- Engineering feature owner for new vehicles as part of an unreleased map
- Bolstered a new remote workflow with git and p4 to support non-technical staff

Raven Software | 3+ proprietary engines, C++, Custom Script Language (GSC), Lua

- Led small team to design, architect, and implement Warzone's Ping Marker system
- Built an automated testing tool to assist Design and QA on CoD's first Battle Royale
- Designed & built player ranking system; Used live metrics to tune rewards
- Profiled code and established standards to reduce live service errors by tenfold

Selected Career History

ZeniMax Online Studios (Xbox, Bethesda)

Unannounced AAA MMORPG

Accessibility Team Lead and Principal Technical Designer
Senior Technical Designer

July 2023 – July 2025
August 2021 – July 2023

PUBG Corporation

PlayerUnknown's Battlegrounds (PUBG)

Software Engineer

October 2020 – July 2021

Raven Software (Activision Blizzard)

Call of Duty: Warzone, Call of Duty: Modern Warfare, Call of Duty: Cold War,

Call of Duty: Black Ops IIII, Call of Duty: Online (China)

Gameplay Engineer
Associate Gameplay Engineer
Gameplay Engineer Intern

May 2016 – October 2020
May 2016 – February 2018
Summer 2015

Education

University of Wisconsin-Madison

Computer Sciences and Linguistics